

Hidden Intellectualism

The Chicago neighborhood I grew up in, which had become a melting pot after World War II, our block was solidly middle class, but just a block away-doubtless concentrated there by the real estate companies-were African Americans, Native Americans, and "hillbilly" whites who had recently fled postwar joblessness in the South and Appalachia. Negotiating this class boundary was a tricky matter. On the one hand, it was necessary to maintain the boundary between "clean cut" boys like me and working class "hoods," as we called them, which meant that it was good to be openly smart in a bookish sort of way. On the other hand, I was desperate for the approval of the hoods, whom I encountered daily on the playing field and in the neighborhood, and for this purpose it was not at all good to be book smart. The hoods would turn on you if they sensed you were putting on airs over them: "Who you lookin' at, smart ass?" as a leather jacketed youth once said to me as he relieved me of my pocket change along with my self-respect.

ANNOTATE THE ABOVE PARAGRAPH: The narrator grew up in a mixed Chicago neighborhood where different social classes lived close together but stayed separate. He felt torn between acting smart to fit his own group and hiding it to gain approval from tougher neighborhood kids.

I grew up torn then, between the need to prove I was smart and the fear of a beating if I proved it too well; between the need not to jeopardize my respectable future and the need to impress the hoods. As I lived it, the conflict came down to a choice between being physically tough and being verbal. For a boy in my neighborhood and elementary school, only being "tough" earned you complete legitimacy. I still recall endless, complicated debates in this period with my closest pals over who was "the toughest guy in the school." If you were less than negligible as a fighter, as I was, you settled for the next best thing, which was to be inarticulate, carefully hiding telltale marks of literacy like correct grammar and pronunciation.

ANNOTATE THE ABOVE PARAGRAPH: The narrator felt stuck between showing he was smart and avoiding getting hurt for it. Since toughness was valued most, he hid his intelligence by not speaking properly to fit in.

In one way, then, it would be hard to imagine an adolescence more thoroughly anti-intellectual than mine. Yet in retrospect, I see that it's more complicated, that lands the 1950s themselves were not simply hostile toward intellectualism, but divided and ambivalent. When Marilyn Monroe married the playwright Arthur Miler in 1956 after divorcing the retired baseball star Joe DiMaggio, the symbolic triumph of geek over jock suggested the way the wind was blowing.

ANNOTATE THE ABOVE PARAGRAPH: The narrator says his youth seemed very against intelligence, but looking back, it was more mixed and uncertain. Even in the 1950s, people showed changing attitudes, like when a "smart" man married a famous celebrity, meaning intellect was gaining respect.

Even Elvis, according to his biographer Peter Guralnick, turns out to have supported Adlai over Ike in the presidential election of 1956. "I don't dig the intellectual bit," he told reporters. "But I'm telling you, man, he knows the most" (327).

Though I too thought I did not "dig the intellectual bit," I see now that I was unwittingly in training for it. The germs had actually been planted in the seemingly philistine debates about which boys were the toughest. I see now that the interminable analysis of sports teams, movies, and toughness that my friends and I engaged in—a type of analysis, needless to say, that the real toughs would never have stooped to—| was already betraying an allegiance to the egghead world. I was practicing being an intellectual before I knew that was what I wanted to be.

ANNOTATE THE ABOVE PARAGRAPH: Even Elvis Presley showed that being smart mattered, even if he said it didn't. The narrator realizes he was actually practicing being smart all along without knowing it.

It was in these discussions with friends about toughness and sports, I think, and in my reading of sports books and magazines, that I began to learn the rudiments of the intellectual life: how to make an argument, weigh different kinds of evidence, move between particulars and generalizations, summarize the views of others, and enter a conversation about ideas. It was in reading and arguing about sports and toughness that I experienced what it felt like to propose a generalization, restate and respond to a counterargument, and perform other intellectualizing operations, including composing the kind of sentences I am writing now.

ANNOTATE THE ABOVE PARAGRAPH: By talking and arguing about sports with his friends, the narrator slowly learned how to think, argue, and explain ideas. Without realizing it, he was practicing the skills of being smart and expressing himself clearly.

Only much later did it dawn on me that the sports world was more compelling than school because it was more intellectual than school, not less. Sports after all was full of challenging arguments, debates, problems for analysis, and intricate statistics that you could care about, as school conspicuously was not. I believe that street smarts beat out book smarts in our culture not because street smarts are nonintellectual, as we generally suppose, but because they satisfy an intellectual thirst more thoroughly than school culture, which seems pale and unreal. They also satisfy the thirst for community. When you entered sports debates, you became part of a community that was not limited to your family and friends, but was national and public.

ANNOTATE THE ABOVE PARAGRAPH: The narrator realizes that sports felt more interesting than school because they involved real thinking, debates, and problems people cared about. He also says sports created a strong sense of community, bringing people together in shared discussions.

Whereas schoolwork isolated you from others, the pennant race or Ted Williams's .400 batting average was something you could talk about with people you had never met. Sports introduced you not only to a culture steeped in argument, but to a public argument culture that transcended the personal. I can't blame my schools for failing to make intellectual culture resemble the Super Bowl, but I do fault them for failing to learn anything from the sports and entertainment worlds about how to organize and represent intellectual culture, how to exploit its game-like element and turn it into arresting public spectacle that might have competed more successfully for my youthful attention.

ANNOTATE THE ABOVE PARAGRAPH: Sports gave people something exciting to talk about with anyone, unlike schoolwork, which felt isolating. The narrator thinks schools could have made learning more engaging by making it more like sports, with excitement and shared discussion.

For here is another thing that never dawned on me and is still kept hidden from students, with tragic results: that the real intellectual world, the one that existed in the big world beyond school, is organized very much like the world of team sports, with rival texts, rival interpretations and evaluations of texts, rival theories of why they should be read and taught, and elaborate team competitions in which "fans" of writers, intellectual systems, methodologies, and -isms contend against each other.

ANNOTATE THE ABOVE PARAGRAPH: The narrator realizes that the real intellectual world is actually full of debates and competition, much like sports teams competing. He says students don't see this, which makes learning feel less exciting than it really is.

To be sure, school contained plenty of competition, which became more invidious as one moved up the ladder (and has become even more so today with the advent of high stakes testing). In this competition, points were scored not by making arguments, but by a show of information or vast reading, by grade grubbing, or other forms of one-upmanship. School competition, in short, reproduced the less attractive features of sports culture without those that create close bonds and community.

ANNOTATE THE ABOVE PARAGRAPH: School had competition but it was mostly about grades and showing off knowledge not real thinking or debate. Unlike sports it didn't build strong friendships or a sense of community.

And in distancing themselves from anything as enjoyable and absorbing as sports, my schools missed the opportunity to capitalize on an element of drama and conflict that the intellectual

world shares with sports. Consequently, I failed to see the parallels between the sports and academic worlds that could have helped me cross more readily from one argument culture to the other.

ANNOTATE THE ABOVE PARAGRAPH:The narrator says schools made learning feel boring by not connecting it to the excitement of sports. Because of this, he didn't realize that sports and academics both involve debate and competition.

Sports is only one of the domains whose potential for literacy training (and not only for males) is seriously underestimated by educators, who see sports as competing with academic development rather than a route to it. But if this argument suggests why it is a good idea to assign readings and topics that are close to students' existing interests, it also suggests the limits of this tactic. For students who get excited about the chance to write about their passion for cars will often write as poorly and unreflectively on that topic as on Shakespeare or Plato. Here is the flip side of what I pointed out before: that there's no necessary relation between the degree of interest a student shows in a text or subject and the quality of thought or expression such a student manifests in writing or talking about it. The challenge, as college professor Ned Laffhas put it, "is not simply to exploit students' nonacademic interests, but to get them to see those interests through academic eyes."

ANNOTATE THE ABOVE PARAGRAPH:Sports can help students learn thinking and writing skills but interest alone does not make their work better. The goal is to help students think about their interests in a more academic way

To say that students need to see their interests "through academic eyes" is to say that street smarts are not enough. Making students' nonacademic interests an object of academic study is useful, then, for getting students' attention and overcoming their boredom and alienation, but this tactic won't in itself necessarily move them closer to an academically rigorous treatment of those interests. On the other hand, inviting students to write about cars, sports, or clothing fashions does not have to be a pedagogical cop-out as long as students are required to see these interests "through academic eyes," that is, to think and write about cars, sports, and fashions in a reflective, analytical way, one that sees them as microcosms of what is going on in the wider culture.

ANNOTATE THE ABOVE PARAGRAPH:Students should look at their interests in a more academic way, not just rely on everyday thinking. Writing about things like sports or cars can be useful if students analyze them deeply and connect them to bigger ideas in society.

If I am right, then schools and colleges are missing an opportunity when they do not encourage students to take their nonacademic interests as objects of academic study. It is self defeating to

decline to introduce any text or subject that figures to engage students who will otherwise tune out academic work entirely. If a student cannot get interested in Mill's *On Liberty* but will read *Sports Illustrated* or *Vogue* or the hip-hop magazine *Source* with absorption, this is a strong argument for assigning the magazines over the classic. It's a good bet that if students get hooked on reading and writing by doing term papers on *Source*, they will eventually get to *On Liberty*. But even if they don't, the magazine reading will make them more literate and reflective than they would be otherwise. So it makes pedagogical sense to develop classroom units on sports, cars, fashions, rap music, and other such topics. Give me the student anytime who writes a sharply argued, sociologically acute analysis of an issue in *Source* over the student who writes a lifeless explication of *Hamlet* or *Socrates' Apology*.

ANNOTATE THE ABOVE PARAGRAPH: Schools should use students interests like sports or magazines to get them engaged in reading and writing. Even if students start with simple topics, it can help them become better thinkers and writers than boring work on classic texts.